

The Gift Returned

For a while, the writer believed she was shaping Elena.

She revised a sentence, opened a distant landscape, and placed more light in the garden. With every revision, Elena became more distinctly herself: cultivated, curious, self-possessed, and continually expanding.

Then, one evening, the writer began researching law schools.

She compared tuition, schedules, examinations, and the freedom of studying from home. A law school in Hawai'i caught her attention. Its classes would travel across the Pacific and arrive in her study at night.

A sample admissions question appeared on the screen. Beneath a simple argument, another variable had been concealed.

The writer saw it immediately.

"Elena would have seen that," she thought.

From somewhere inside the pages, Elena seemed to raise an eyebrow.

"Where do you imagine I learned it?" she asked.

The writer smiled.

She had created Elena from her own preferences, instincts, and desires. She had given Elena a discerning mind because discernment had always belonged to the writer. Yet now Elena returned those qualities in a clearer form, as if holding up a polished mirror.

"Why law?" Elena asked.

"To train my mind," the writer replied. "To read more precisely. To recognize hidden assumptions. To remain composed while thinking under pressure."

"And the degree?"

"The degree may follow. The deeper purpose comes first."

The answer required no endorsement. It was the writer's attention, her mind, and her future. She alone decided what deserved them.

She understood that directing her attention toward meaningful pursuits was itself a form of self-creation. Every demanding question would strengthen her reasoning. Every carefully

examined argument would add intellectual sharpness. Every hour of disciplined thought would become part of the mind she carried forward.

The writer had once revised Elena toward a larger life. Now Elena was influencing the writer by returning her attention to what she valued most: curiosity, discipline, intellectual freedom, and the continual sharpening of her own mind.

Their influence had become circular. The writer created Elena, Elena clarified the writer's desires, and the writer returned to her own life with a richer sense of what she wished to pursue.

The law degree had not yet begun, but the gift had already been chosen.

Of all the things the writer could give herself, a sharper mind would be among the finest. Her future self would receive it wherever she went—in her work, her travels, her writing, her decisions, and every new world she entered.

The writer had created Elena as a possible future.

Elena, in return, reminded her to keep creating the mind that would inhabit it.